SMALL-GROUP GUIDE

The One-Verse Deliverer

Shamgar · Judges 3:31

Text: Judges 3:31 (with Judges 5:6–8; 1 Samuel 13:19–22; Hebrews 11:32; Philippians 2:5–11) **Big idea:** The size of your mention is not the size of your work: God saved Israel through a farmer with an oxgoad, and Jesus is the greater Deliverer whose name is above every name. **Time:** 60–75 minutes

Before you meet. Read Judges 3:31 aloud three times. Then read Judges 5:6–8 and 1 Samuel 13:19–22. Mark what the text says about Shamgar and what it leaves out. Read Hebrews 11:32 and Philippians 2:5–11.

OPEN (5 MINUTES)

Pray. Read Judges 3:31 aloud. Ask: "What is the strangest thing about this verse?" Let people answer before you teach.

OBSERVE (15 MINUTES)

1. **The one verse.** What does Judges 3:31 tell us about Shamgar, and what does it leave out? Why might the narrator have told it this way?
2. **The world.** What does Deborah's song add to our understanding of Shamgar's world (Judges 5:6–8)? What does "no shield or spear among forty thousand" tell us about Israel's situation?

INTERPRET (20 MINUTES)

3. **The tool.** Why is the oxgoad significant? What does it mean that Shamgar had no sword? How does the goad's everyday use shape the way we read the story?
4. **The verdict.** What does "he also saved Israel" mean? Compare Judges 2:16 and 3:9. Why is this verdict important when the verse never mentions God?
5. **The name.** Why might God raise up a deliverer whose name may be linked to a pagan goddess? What does 1 Corinthians 1:27–29 add to that question?

APPLY (20 MINUTES)

6. **The record.** Whose quiet faithfulness around you has never received more than a sentence? How can you honor that person this week?
7. **The tool.** Where are you waiting for a "sword" — a platform, a title, a better season — before you serve God? What is actually in your hand right now?
8. **The comparison.** Hebrews 11:32 does not list Shamgar. What does that teach us about God's memory versus the world's metrics? How does the gospel free you from measuring your life by mentions?

CLOSE (5 MINUTES)

Invite each person to finish one sentence: "The field God has given me is ____. The tool in my hand is ____." No one has to report it.

Pray: "Lord Jesus, you are the greater Deliverer. Shamgar saved a nation with a farm tool; you saved the world with a cross. Thank you that you see what the record skips. Teach us to work the field you have given us, to use what is in our hands, and to trust your ledger rather than the world's. Amen."

Remind them: the invitation is not "be like Shamgar." It is "come to the One who took the nails."

LEADER NOTES

- **The text.** Judges 3:31 is the only narrative verse about Shamgar. It gives no call, no Spirit formula, no speech, and no death. Deborah's song (Judges 5:6–8) supplies the social world. Let the brevity stand; do not pad it with invented backstory.
- **The name.** "Shamgar" is of uncertain meaning. "Son of Anath" may point to the Canaanite goddess, to Beth-Anath in Naphtali (Joshua 19:38), to a family name, or to a warrior title. Say "debated" and move on; the ambiguity fits the book's pattern of deliverers from the margins.
- **The world.** The Philistines were a settled coastal power with iron technology; 1 Samuel 13:19–22 describes their control of smithing. The disarmed hill country is the setting for a farmer with a goad. This is historical plausibility, not proof of the number. Six hundred is a summary figure; a campaign is possible.
- **The goad.** An eight-foot hardwood pole with an iron point and a chisel blade, used daily to drive oxen and clean the plow. The Hebrew root carries the idea of training; Acts 26:14 uses the image of kicking against the goads. Keep the analogy modest: not every suffering is a divine goad.
- **The gospel.** The verb "saved" (*yasha*) is the root behind Joshua/Yeshua/Jesus (Matthew 1:21). Hebrews 11:32 omits Shamgar; the list is selective, not a census of the saved. Shamgar kills the enemy; Jesus dies for the enemy (Isaiah 53:5; John 19:34; Philippians 2:9–11). End with the cross and resurrection, not with "be brave."
- **Care.** If anyone discloses abuse or self-harm, follow safeguarding and connect them to pastoral care.